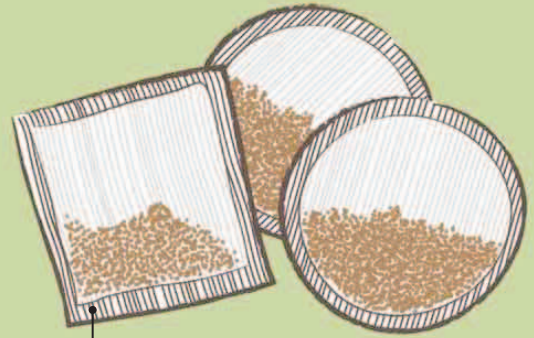


TEA BAG

The tea bag was an accidental invention. In 1908, Thomas Sullivan, a tea merchant from New York City, sent his clients samples of tea in small silk drawstring bags. He expected them to remove the leaves from the bag before infusing them, but they brewed the tea directly, in the bags, and were so pleased with the results that they asked for more to be sent similarly packaged.



Tea bags are available in round or square sachets (above), which leave little room for the leaves to infuse. The pyramid tea bag (left) is shaped to enable better infusion as the water infiltrates it.



The pyramid tea bag has more infusing space than square or round tea bags.

TEA BAG FANNINGS

Commercial black tea bags contain “fannings,” or pieces of tea leaves considered unsuitable to be sold loose.



CONVENIENCE

The tea bag is convenient to use because it comes in premeasured packs, and eliminates the need for a strainer, teapot, or infuser.

FRESHNESS AND QUALITY

Commercial tea bags are filled with the smallest pieces of the lowest grade commodity black tea. This is one of the reasons why they infuse so quickly, but also why they become stale, regardless of how they are stored, since their surface area is exposed.

FLAVOR

The tea used in tea bags loses many of its essential oils and much of its aroma during processing. As such, tea bags have less complexity of flavor than loose-leaf tea. They also release more tannins when infused, which can result in a bitter and astringent drink.

VALUE

A large box of tea bags is relatively inexpensive, but the price per cup is similar to that of loose leaf, especially when you consider that loose-leaf tea can be used for multiple infusions and tea bags only once. Tea bags also have a shorter shelf life.

ENVIRONMENTAL FRIENDLINESS

Although some types of tea bag are fully biodegradable, the majority contain small amounts of plastic (polypropylene) that will remain in a compost pile for years. Look for bags that are polypropylene-free.

INFUSION

Tea bags are easy to infuse, even without a teapot, but restrict the movement of tea leaves that is required to make a really good cup of tea.